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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Plainfield man convicted in boy's death



Faces life in prison for hate crime slaying of Palestinian American

By Michelle Mullins
Chicago Tribune

Joseph Czuba was convicted Friday of murdering 6-year-old Wadee Alfayoumi, a hate crime fueled by the Plainfield landlord's hostility toward Palestinians and his anger over the Hamas attack against Israel on Oct. 7, 2023.

A Will County jury deliberated for just over an hour before reaching a verdict of guilty. Czuba did not display any visible signs of emotion when the verdict was read.

The panel also found him guilty of attempted murder of the boy's mother, two counts of aggravated battery and two counts of committing a hate crime.

Czuba, 73, faces life in prison without parole. He did not testify during the four-day trial. Sentencing is scheduled for May 2.

After the verdict, Wadee's father, Odai Alfayoumi, said through a translator that he was thankful justice will be served but was feeling mixed emotions.

"I don't know if I should be pleased or upset, if I should be crying or laughing," Alfayoumi said. "People are telling me to smile. Maybe if I were one of you, I would be smiling. But I'm the father of a child and I have lost the child, and I feel like this decision

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Family and supporters of Wadee Alfayoumi attend a Friday news conference at the Will County Courthouse after a jury found Joseph Czuba guilty on all charges in the murder of the boy. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE**

Two cartel figures brought to Chicago

Historic prisoner transfer begins as Trump ramps up pressure on Mexico

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Two reputed high-ranking Mexican cartel figures landed in Chicago on Thursday as part of a historic prisoner transfer with Mexico as the administration of President Donald Trump turns up the pressure on drug trafficking organizations, federal authorities said.

Norberto Valencia González, a financial guru affiliated with the once-powerful and notoriously violent Beltrán-Leyva cartel, was extradited to Chicago and made an initial court appearance Thursday on an indictment alleging he conspired to traffic kilogram quantities of cocaine and launder drug proceeds, according to court records.

The trafficking activity took place between 2013 and 2017 in Chicago and nearby areas, including Arlington Heights, Morris and Plainfield, the seven-page indictment states.

An arraignment and detention hearing for González was set for next week before U.S. Magistrate Judge David Weisman.

Also coming to Chicago was José Ángel Canobbio-Inzunza, an alleged aide and security chief for the Sinaloa cartel once headed by Joaquín "El Chapo" Guzmán.

An indictment unveiled last year accused Canobbio-Inzunza, 44, of assisting one of Guzmán's sons, who took over the business after their father's arrest, with manufacturing and importing cocaine, methamphetamine, fentanyl and marijuana to the U.S. for sale. The charges also alleged Inzunza financed and ran the cartel's security arm, known as Los Chinales.

Inzunza pleaded not guilty during a hearing Thursday before U.S. District Judge Martha Pacold, before the prisoner deal was

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Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and President Donald Trump spar Friday in the Oval Office. **ANDREW HARNIK/GETTY**

Heated exchange halts White House meeting

Trump, VP berate Ukraine's Zelenskyy during visit to Oval Office

By Will Weissert, Zeke Miller and Justin Spike
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump berated Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy for being "disrespectful" Friday in an extraordinary Oval Office meeting, then abruptly called off the signing of a minerals deal with the U.S. that Trump said would have moved Ukraine closer to ending its war with Russia.

The astonishing turn of events

could scramble international affairs in Europe and around the globe. During his visit with Trump, Zelenskyy had planned to sign the deal allowing the U.S. greater access to Ukraine's rare earth minerals, then hold a joint news conference.

It's unclear what the blowup could mean for the deal that Trump insisted was essential to repay the U.S. for the more than \$180 billion in American aid sent to Kyiv since the start of the war. And it remains to be seen what, if

anything, Trump wants Zelenskyy to do to get the deal back on track.

Instead, Ukraine's leader left the White House shortly after Trump shouted at him, showing open disdain.

The White House said the Ukraine delegation was told to leave.

"You're gambling with World War III, and what you're doing is very disrespectful to the country, this country that's backed you far more than a lot of people say they should have," Trump told

Zelenskyy.

The last 10 minutes of the nearly 45-minute meeting devolved into a tense back and forth between Trump, Vice President JD Vance and Zelenskyy, who had urged skepticism about Russia's commitment to diplomacy, citing Moscow's years of broken commitments on the global stage.

Zelenskyy's main objective going into the sit-down had been

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Hackman, wife cause of death unknown

Legendary actor Gene Hackman and his wife tested negative for carbon monoxide, but what caused their deaths remains unknown, the sheriff leading the investigation said Friday. Hackman likely was dead more than a week because his pacemaker last showed activity on Feb. 17. **Nation & World**

Democrats appeal to public over Medicaid

Top Illinois Democrats, led by Gov. JB Pritzker and Sen. Dick Durbin, on Friday made an impassioned plea for the public to help fight potential cuts to Medicaid and other programs by President Donald Trump and Republicans who control Congress. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Concerns raised over Albany Park school's boiler

Parents worried about gas smell, heating woes affecting their children

By Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

Regina Tafolla said there wasn't enough heat in her children's elementary school classrooms during last week's freezing temperatures.

Volta Elementary School's boiler had been having issues with a gas-like odor since November, so she wasn't surprised, she said.

"If you go near the school, you'll notice that it smells a lot like gas. The principal said he called the gas company. The firefighters also came," she said. "Their solution was to turn off the heat."

Only part of the school in Albany Park didn't have heat, parents said, so it is not clear how many of Volta's 738 students were affected. But parents said their kids told them they had to wear jackets and it lasted for several days.

Like many in the district, Volta is an old building. The three-story, 86,000-square-foot school was built in 1931, according to records, with several additions in the '90s.

CPS has acknowledged the challenges of having older facilities — saying in a 2023 building plan that over \$3 billion in "critical repairs" are needed. The district is required by law to produce a plan every five years, and the cost for critical repairs is

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Regina Tafolla, center, watches her children, Bella, 2, and Marazan, 9, as Tafolla and fellow parent Sonia Velasquez talk at Volta Elementary School in Chicago while their children play during a professional development day off for students on Tuesday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

